

PRODUCT CASE STUDY: GEMINI "SECRET VAULT"

Author: Aniruddh Singh Jhala

Role: Aspiring Associate Product Manager (APM)

1. Context & Executive Summary

Google Gemini recently introduced "**Temporary Chats**"—a feature allowing users to have off-the-record conversations that are completely private and not used for training AI models. While this solves severe privacy concerns, it introduces a major product bottleneck: **Instant User Regret**. As per Gemini's current product behavior, temporary chats disappear **instantly and permanently the exact moment a user exits the chat window, closes the app, or refreshes the page**.

This severe data volatility means users frequently realize *immediately after* exiting a highly valuable session that they forgot to save an important snippet or summary. This case study proposes a "**Secret Vault**" feature—a secure, stealth-designed environment within Gemini that allows users to permanently save and lock specific "starred" elements *during* an active temporary chat session, before it disappears from the screen forever.

2. Problem Statement

Because Gemini wipes out temporary chats immediately upon window closure, there is zero time buffer or session history. Users frequently extract high-value insights (code blocks, research outlines, or personal data) during these private sessions. If a user accidentally closes the browser tab, clicks away, or switches apps, the data is completely lost with no recovery path. This creates a high-friction experience and user anxiety during creative or complex tasks.

3. Proposed Solution: The Secret Vault

A secure, encrypted vault embedded natively inside Gemini that acts as a safe repository for selective temporary data before a session is terminated.

Key Product Mechanics:

- **Core Interaction (The Star Mechanism):** Inside an active temporary chat session, a user can long-press or click a message to "Star" it. The star serves as an immediate

migration trigger. When the user eventually exits the chat, the regular logs vanish as intended, but the starred elements safely migrate to the Vault.

- **Stealth UX Placement:** To maintain maximum peer-to-peer privacy, the Vault entry link is completely hidden from the main sidebar. It is placed deep within **Menu (3 Lines) -> Settings -> Secret Vault**.

4. Edge Cases & User Flow (Product Requirements)

High-Fidelity Product Flow:

1. **Onboarding / First-Time Setup:** When a user taps the Secret Vault for the first time, they are prompted to set up a unique 4-to-6 digit PIN.
2. **Destructive Action Warning:** Before finalizing the PIN, the system displays a clear warning screen:
"Warning: For your ultimate privacy, this PIN cannot be reset without consequences. If you choose to reset a forgotten PIN via your linked account, your entire Secret Vault will be permanently wiped out to protect your data."
3. **Forgot PIN Scenario:** If a user forgets their PIN, they can authenticate via Gmail to override it. However, this triggers an automatic data-wipe script, ensuring that an unauthorized person holding the device cannot bypass security to view hidden logs.

5. Analytics, Success Metrics & Rollout

To determine whether the Secret Vault feature is a success or a failure, we track core feature engagement rather than superficial vanity metrics:

- **Core Feature Engagement:** Total number of temporary messages "Starred" per week. (Measures active value extraction).
- **Feature Retention Rate:** % of users who return to open the Secret Vault within 7 to 14 days of starring a chat. (Ensures the feature loop closes and users actually find their saved data).

Go-To-Market (GTM) Rollout Strategy:

- **Target Audience:** Phased rollout starting with a 10% beta-testing pool focused on the **18-25 age demographic (Students and Freshers)** on Android.
- **Rationale:** This cohort represents Gemini's highest power-user base, interacts frequently with sensitive temporary logs, provides rapid feedback loops, and prioritizes strict peer-to-peer device privacy.